

■ By Uday Mahurkar

The elections may be several weeks away, but the battle plans are already on display. The dissident camp within the BJP has started to gather steam in their bid to topple Chief Minister Narendra Damodardas Modi. Following the Tehelka expose on the Gujarat Government's role and the chief minister's complicity in the 2002 riots, rebel BJP leader and political heavyweight Keshubhai Patel appeared on the same platform as the other rebels for the first time on November 1 at Dhoraji. These rebels have joined hands with the Congress under the aegis of the Sardar Patel Utkarsh

Samiti to oust Modi. Cleverly countering Modi's electoral plank of development, Patel said: "Even Lanka was very developed. In fact, the houses in Lanka were made of gold. Still, Ravana had to be vanquished because he was unprincipled and insensitive." Even as some BJP strategists are projecting Patel's son Bharat as a potential party candidate from Junagarh, Patel has shut the door on any possible patch-up by taking on his bete noire in public.

As if that were not enough, the anti-Modi camp has been bolstered by the presence of Bharatiya Janshakti Party founder Uma Bharati, who has been roped in to split the BJP vote. Bharati held a meeting with Patel before touring Saurashtra, the rebel stronghold,

reiterating her resolve to defeat Modi by forming a third front with the help of disgruntled VHP, RSS and Bharatiya Kisan Sangh leaders and the saints. It seems unlikely, however, that she will be able to pull her punches. The fire-brand leader said, "Modi is a man of destruction. Gujarat is in the grip of fear under his regime. The law and order situation has collapsed. The state is not safe for women anymore. Modi is an icon of false Hindutva, who is tormenting the saffron brigade. He has to be defeated."

Though Bharati has declared that she won't allow the Congress to be the beneficiary of the campaign, he candidates are expected to contest from constituencies where the Congress

THE BATTLE HEATS UP

With the state polls just a few weeks away and the Tehelka expose surfacing, Narendra Modi's opponents gang up to lure the votebank and put up a tough fight against the two-time chief minister



HEMMED IN: The anti-Modi campaign gathers steam

Photographs by SHAILESH RAVAL